

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Human Resources English

Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For HR business partners, recruiters, talent managers, people managers, employee-relations staff, learning teams, compensation analysts, and HR-adjacent leaders.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

accommodation

An adjustment intended to address a person's access or participation needs.

accountability

Responsibility for explaining decisions and following through on agreed work.

behavioral example

A specific description of what a person did or said.

benefits

Non-wage parts of an employment package, such as leave or insurance arrangements.

bias

A systematic tendency that can distort judgment, measurement, selection, or results.

candidate experience

An applicant's experience of an organization's hiring process.

compliance

Conformance with laws, regulations, standards, policies, contracts, or approved procedures.

confidentiality

Protecting information from disclosure to people who are not authorized to receive it.

documentation

Written evidence of what was done, why, by whom, when, and under which authority.

employee relations

Managing workplace relationships, concerns, disputes, and related organizational processes.

equity review

An examination of differences in pay, access, or outcomes for fairness under defined criteria.

expectation

A stated or assumed understanding of what should happen or be delivered.

harassment

Unwelcome conduct assessed under applicable workplace rules and law; specific legal definitions vary.

job level

A position's place in an organization's framework of responsibility and complexity.

job requirement

A capability, qualification, or responsibility needed for a role.

manager check-in

A short discussion between a manager and employee about progress, needs, or expectations.

mediation

A process in which a neutral third party helps participants work toward resolving a disagreement.

onboarding

The process of helping a new employee or customer begin effectively.

operating agreement

An agreed description of how people will coordinate work and responsibilities.

pay band

An organization's defined pay range for a role or group of roles.

performance gap

The difference between expected and observed performance.

policy

Formal rule or standard that guides decisions and behavior.

position elimination

The removal of a job role from an organization's structure.

precedent

An earlier decision or example relevant to a later one; legal authority depends on context.

restructuring

A significant change to an organization's roles, reporting lines, or operations.

retaliation

Adverse treatment in response to protected reporting or activity, as defined by applicable rules.

role clarity

A shared understanding of a person's responsibilities and authority.

severance

Pay or benefits associated with employment termination under the relevant agreement or rules.

structured interview

An interview using planned job-related questions and consistent evaluation criteria.

success measure

An agreed indicator used to judge whether an objective has been achieved.

support plan

Agreed actions and resources intended to help a person or team meet an identified need.

talking points

Prepared key messages intended to guide a conversation or presentation.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Ask a precise question

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Ask for an actionable next step

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Give feedback people can use

In [specific situation], I noticed

The effect was What was happening from your perspective?

Could we agree to ... and review it ...?

Use a specific example instead of a personality label. Explain its effect, invite the person's perspective, and agree on a practical improvement. Focus on communication that can be changed, not accent or national identity.

Match certainty to evidence

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Make a complex point clear

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Help a group reach a clear next step

Let's hear ... before we decide.

The point we still need to resolve is

Who will make this decision, and what do they need?

Summarize the issue neutrally, invite missing perspectives, and distinguish discussion from decision. State who can decide and record any unresolved question. Do not assume silence means agreement.

Repair a misunderstanding

My earlier message did not make ... clear.

I'm sorry for The correct information is

Let me check that the revised explanation addresses

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Recruiting, Screening, and Candidate Experience

A hiring manager asks for a candidate with "good cultural fit." The role requirements do not explain which behaviors matter.

Which job-related behaviors do you mean? Let's use clear requirements and consistent interview questions so candidates are assessed against the work the role actually involves.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

02 | Onboarding and Role Clarity

A new starter has accounts and equipment but no first-month priorities. Their manager assumes the onboarding checklist covers expectations.

Could we agree on three first-month priorities and a check-in date? The checklist covers setup; the new starter also needs to know what successful work looks like.

Try it again: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

03 | Performance Feedback and Documentation

An employee's last two reports omitted the agreed summary section. The manager wants to discuss the issue without making a judgment about motivation.

The last two reports did not include the summary section we agreed on. That made review slower. What would help you include it consistently, and can we check the next report together?

Try it again: The recipient disagrees with your interpretation. Return to the observed example, listen, and revise an unsupported assumption.

04 | Employee Relations and Investigations

An employee raises a concern about a colleague. The receiving manager has only one account and is preparing an intake note.

I'll record the concern in the employee's own terms and distinguish reported information from established findings. The appropriate process should determine the next steps; we should not prejudge the outcome.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

05 | Compensation, Benefits, and Equity

An employee sees a published pay range and assumes everyone in the role receives the midpoint. The HR team has the relevant compensation policy.

The range describes the span for the role, not a promise of the midpoint. Let's review the applicable policy and the factors the organization uses to explain an individual's position within the range.

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

06 | Policy Communication and Compliance

A manager asks whether a requested work adjustment is automatically approved. HR has not yet reviewed the request under the applicable process.

Could you describe the requested adjustment and the work requirement involved? We'll review it through the appropriate process. I cannot confirm an outcome before that review.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

07 | Conflict Mediation and Manager Coaching

Two colleagues disagree about who owns a recurring task. Both say the other failed to help, but the responsibilities were never documented.

Let's identify the task, the handoff point, and what each person understood. Then we can agree on responsibilities and a check-in instead of continuing with assumptions about intent.

Try it again: A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

08 | Restructuring and Sensitive Communication

A restructuring message uses the phrase "small changes" even though some positions may be affected. The final details are not yet confirmed.

The wording may understate the possible impact. Let's say clearly what is confirmed, what remains undecided, and where employees can ask questions, using the approved communication process.

Try it again: The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.